

For the President

4 October 2026

Iran Ceasefire Holds on a Knife's Edge as Washington Weighs Post-Midterm Options

We assess that the US-Iran ceasefire, more than seven months into the war, remains intact but fragile, and that President Trump has moved this week to extend it rather than resume strikes, conditioning any settlement on Tehran producing a single proposal backed by all its factions. We judge the pause is tactical on both sides, and a return to active hostilities is a realistic possibility if the talks stall.

- US forces continue to enforce a naval blockade of Iranian ports and sustain air operations; the Navy has kept two carrier strike groups on station, with the Theodore Roosevelt group now operating in the Arabian Sea.
- Iran's leadership remains divided — the President has described “three or four groups” in Tehran — the principal obstacle to a unified negotiating position and a risk that any deal is repudiated.
- We expect no major US military move before the 3 November midterms; the decision point comes if Iran fails to deliver a consolidated proposal.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from CIA, DIA, NSA, INR, and open sources.

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G7 Opens Emergency Fuel Reserves To Blunt War-Driven Price Spike

We assess that the G7's 2 October decision to release up to 100 million barrels of crude and refined products, front-loaded on diesel, is aimed as much at domestic politics as at the physical market, and that its price relief will likely prove partial and temporary absent an end to the Iran war. The IEA is coordinating the drawdown, with a substantial diesel release promised within roughly 20 days and the rest over four months.

- Diesel futures in Europe and the United States fell on the announcement; Brent crude dipped then recovered, consistent with a market that reads the release as a stopgap.
- US pressure drove the timing: high fuel costs tied to the war have become a liability ahead of the midterms, and the President said the diesel release would begin "immediately."
- We assess prices will stay elevated while Gulf supply is disrupted; strategic stocks are finite and cannot substitute for restored supply.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from the Treasury Office of Intelligence and Analysis, CIA, INR, and open sources.

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Russia Opens Its Winter Campaign Against Ukraine's Power Grid

We assess that Russia's large-scale combined missile-and-drone strike overnight marks the start of its annual cold-season campaign to break Ukraine's electricity network, at far greater intensity than the daily harassment of recent months. Ukrainian officials reported strikes on energy facilities across Kyiv and several regions, at least four killed in the capital, and emergency blackouts imposed by Ukrenergo.

- In Kyiv, drones struck the support structure of the Pivdennyi Bridge, forcing suspension of metro and surface transport across the Dnipro.
- Ukrainian reporting, citing documents reviewed by European partners, indicates planning for a campaign of up to 1,000 missiles, drones, and bombs to collapse the grid before winter.
- For Washington and NATO, the implication is demand: Kyiv will press for more air-defense interceptors, which are in short supply across the alliance.

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Brazil Votes in a First Round That Could Reset the Hemisphere's Largest Democracy

Brazilians vote today in the first round of a presidential election pitting 80-year-old incumbent Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva, seeking a fourth term, against Senator Flavio Bolsonaro of the Liberal Party, carrying his family's banner after his father was barred from office. We assess Lula leads but is unlikely to clear the 50-percent-plus-one threshold, making a 25 October runoff the probable outcome.

- Late polling put Lula in the high-30s and Bolsonaro in the mid-30s; a corruption probe touching the government has narrowed the race.
- For Washington, the result shapes cooperation on trade, the Amazon, and counter-narcotics, and Brazil's posture within BRICS, where Brasilia has pushed de-dollarization and closer ties with Beijing.
- We will watch tonight's margins for whether the contest consolidates into a clean two-way runoff.

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Populist United List Wins Latvian Election; Pro-Ukraine Line Likely To Hold

We assess that Prime Minister Andris Kulbergs's United List won Saturday's Latvian parliamentary election decisively, taking roughly 35 percent and about 42 of the Saeima's 100 seats on preliminary returns, while the long-dominant New Unity collapsed to around 6 percent. We judge Kulbergs is positioned to lead the next government and that Riga's strongly pro-NATO, pro-Ukraine posture is likely to continue.

- Several governing-coalition parties lost ground, so coalition-building may be protracted; turnout was about 52 percent.
- For Washington, Latvia is a front-line NATO state bordering Russia and Belarus, hosts allied forces, and is among the most hawkish European backers of Ukraine.
- We will watch the coalition talks for any party seeking to soften sanctions or defense commitments, which we judge unlikely to prevail.

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North Korea Resumes Ballistic Testing After a Lull

We assess that North Korea's launch of multiple ballistic missiles toward the Sea of Japan early today (the evening of 3 October in Washington) is a calibrated signal timed to allied diplomacy rather than a prelude to a crisis. South Korea's Joint Chiefs and Japan's Defense Ministry reported the missiles, fired from near Pyongyang, flew more than 500 miles before splashing down.

- The launch came as Seoul, Washington, and Tokyo coordinate on their combined defense posture; we judge Pyongyang timed it to register displeasure.
- We see no indications of preparations for a nuclear test or a long-range ICBM flight, which would be a more serious escalation.
- For Washington, the significance is alliance management: the launch strengthens the case for trilateral missile-defense coordination.

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Notes

- **France.** Student protests over teacher shortages and crumbling schools escalated this week, merging with a public-sector strike; authorities reported hundreds detained, many of them minors, and hundreds of schools disrupted — pressure on the government as it readies an austere 2027 budget.
- **Energy.** OPEC+ ministers meet today, 4 October, in a session expected to focus on reviewing members' production capacity to set 2027 quotas rather than near-term output, which the group has held steady.

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